

Eggs

The young of many animals develop inside eggs, which provide protection and food. All birds and most fish and insects are egg-layers. Others include reptiles, frogs and toads, slugs and snails, and even a few mammals.

EGG SHAPES

Most commonly, bird eggs are oval-shaped. Seabirds nesting on cliffs lay pear-shaped eggs, which roll in a circle but not off an edge. A few birds, including some owls, lay round eggs.



OVAL
Typical shape for most birds' eggs.



PEAR-SHAPED
Unlikely to roll right off a bare ledge.



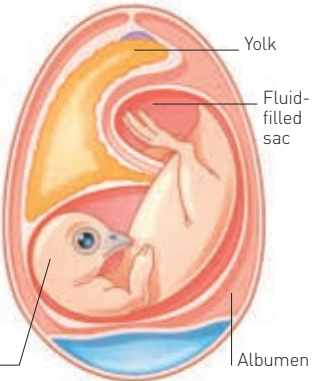
SPHERICAL
Usually laid by birds that build deep nests.



CONICAL
These eggs pack closely in the nest for equal warmth.

INSIDE AN EGG

The developing bird, which is known as the "embryo", is cushioned inside a sac or bag full of fluid. The yellow yolk provides the embryo with most of its food, but the albumen, or "white", also gives it protein and water.



Embryo (developing bird)

CHICKEN EMBRYO INSIDE EGG

BIRD EGGS

Eggs come in lots of different colours and patterns, which may help to camouflage them from predators. The colours partly depend on the diet of the bird. If it eats plenty of calcium – which it might get from foods such as insects – it produces a lighter, whiter egg.

